

Design Principle Card

Day 3 · Activity 4 handout. Convert your audit findings into three design principles your squad can hold the line on across PRDs. Each principle gets one line plus one decision it would force.

What a good design principle is

- A **statement**, not a feature.
- **Decision-making** — it tells you what to choose when two options compete.
- Phrased in the **product's voice**, not the framework's.
- **Memorable** — short enough that an engineer would quote it back.

Calibrating: sharp vs. vacuous

Sharp	Why	Vacuous	Why
"If a dispatcher can't recover from a mis-tap in 1 second, we built it wrong."	Decision-making, specific, memorable	"Be user-friendly"	Says nothing you can act on
"Show the network state on every screen — assume connectivity is broken."	Drives concrete choices	"Use Material Design"	A toolkit, not a principle
"Power users get keyboard shortcuts. New users get them visible too."	Names and resolves a tension	"Be consistent"	True but not actionable

A principle that fails the decision test ("does it tell us what to choose when two options compete?") needs a rewrite before it locks.

The card (fill one per principle, three total)

Principle: <one memorable line>

A decision it would force: <when option A and option B compete, this principle picks ____>

Rooted in audit finding: <which finding / theme this came from>

Your three principles

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Note for the readout: be ready to name the principle you expect the *most disagreement* with your designers on, and why.